41
A View from the Verandah

From the large verandah of the Raj Bhawan at Itanagar, the view of virgin forested hills, the different shades of verdure, the pure spring water of the rivers, the pollution-free environment and the blue sky, makes me go back to my carefree childhood when one read children's classics describing the life of Robinson Crusoe on an isolated but beautiful island. The scenery is perhaps the same, but the scenario of global politics is far more complex now. India is a young and vibrant nation, looking for its rightful place in the comity of nations. So much has changed in these six-and-a-half decades since our independence.

I regard India as a civilizational concept. This was the cherished dream of our forefathers, we are following it, and our children will witness its realization. 'India is not a rising power, it is a world power,' said Barack Obama, the US president, during his visit to India in November 2010. The Indian elephant with its gleaming tusks is taking confident strides into the second decade of the twenty-first century. This has been acclaimed as the century of India and China. With a rising economy and a steady growth rate of around 8 to 9 per cent for the past six to seven years, India is poised to make its impact in the global arena. It has come as no surprise that we hosted visits by the heads of all the P5 countries during 2010. It is a reflection of our growing importance and stature. We are emerging as a deserving permanent member of the UN Security Council and this has been acknowledged by nearly all important nations today. An empowered India can no longer be transgressed or taken for granted.